

A BIOGRAPHICAL SKETCH
of
Notable Contributions Made By
Jesse Abel Francis

Jesse Abel Francis was brought up on a family farm a few miles North of the town of Enfield, Halifax County, North Carolina. Upon graduation from the Daniel Chapel Rosenwald Elementary, and the Eastman High School as a valedictorian of his class in 1939, he enrolled at the A. and T. State University on an academic and 4-H Club Scholarship-- The total of which amounted to only ninety dollars. As a result of this limited help, he didn't loose faith in his ability to help himself. Instead, he became the campus barber, and a campus agent of a local pawn shop. He was elected president of his class at A. and T., and participated in a variety of academic, social, religious, and other extra-curricular activities on the campus. In spite of his self-help responsibilities, he graduated with a 3.6 average with a major in Vocational Education and Biological Science, and minor in Business Administration in 1943.

Immediately upon graduation, Francis was called to serve his country at war during the World War II conflict. After a short training period, he was sent over seas, and served three-plus years in two separate theaters of operation. Upon graduation from the Infantry Officers Candidate School, and serving in a number of other assignments, Francis was assigned to the administrative staff of the Second Manor Port in Manila, the capitol of the Phillipines, as a Personnel Officer--First Lieutenant, Infantry.

When Francis returned to the country in 1946, he accepted the job of teacher of Biological Science and Chemistry at the Eastman High School. After serving one year at his former high school near his home community, he accepted an offer by the N. C. State Department of Vocational Education, and was sent to Brunswick County, North Carolina to establish, supervise, and administer a new occupational training program for 75 newly discharged veterans of the World War II. While serving in this capacity as a teacher of Vocational Education in the high school, and the supervisor of the Veterans Training Program within the county, Francis met his lovely wife of 42 years, a fellow teacher, a musician, and an abiding friend.

Francis's extra activities included the following accomplishments:

1. With the help of his students, he contracted and constructed a modern building consisting of two state-approved industrial shops and two classrooms.
2. Organized and supervised the Brunswick County Credit Union of 385 members that specialized in small agricultural, commercial, and community development loans.
3. As a result of his inovative programs, Francis was appointed by

the Brunswick County Commissioners to serve on the Brunswick County's Resources Development Commission. He served on this commission 23 years beginning as its secretary, and later as the chairman. Concurrently, he was also appointed to serve on the county's Industrial Development Commission. During these 23 years of recruitment and development, in terms of per capita income, Brunswick County rose from the lowest income level among the counties of North Carolina to the second place only to Mecklenburg County in which Charlotte is located.

4. To bring to realization one of his cherished dreams, with the encouragement and cooperation of his devoted wife, Francis established and operated a low-income Housing Rental Business of 11 units, designed for the handicapped, the elderly, the newly wed couples, and any other family that did not have a permanent home. The business was structured and operated under strict state and federal guidelines for 42 years.
5. Even though Francis' commitment to the community had come under full schedule, he used his vacation time to enroll in schools of high learning at which he completed the graduate work for his Masters in Vocational Education at the North Carolina A. & T. State University, and subsequently, he earned his graduate Certification in School Administration from East Carolina University.

As an extended arm of the University Teacher Training and Certification Program, Francis was appointed an itinerant teacher-trainer by the N. C. A. & T. State University. A number of graduating students were placed under his observation for 6 weeks before receiving their certificates and licenses to teach. Three of these candidates were from the African country of Nigeria.

6. In the area of religion and community service, Francis served as Adult Sunday School Teacher for 28 years, Chairman of the Trustee Board and Treasurer of the Friendship Baptist Church for 42 years.
7. While engaged in all of these activities, Francis was employed as principal of the Southport Middle School of 16 professional teachers, six hundred students, and 10 para-professional workers. He was devoted to his profession as indicated by his having been elected and served two terms as president of the Brunswick County Teachers Association. On the state level, Francis was elected and served two terms as president of the North Carolina Association of Vocational Teachers, Inc.
8. Francis' extended social and religious contributions involved his serving as co-director of the Southport-Oak-Island Inter-church Fellowship which consisted of 18 churches of approximately 12 different denominations-- 80% of these churches were white churches, and 20% were Black churches. Adding to his involvement in this area, Francis also served as Chairman of the Trustee Board of the Ocean View Missionary Baptist Association for which he designed and supervised the construction of its \$350,000.00 Headquarters Building, located on 15 acres of land bordering on U.S. Highway 17, at Grissetown, North Carolina.

9. As his contribution to justice, fidelity, and human rights, Francis was appointed by the city of Southport to serve as chairman of its Board of Adjustment and Review. The City Council also appointed him Co-director of the historic Southport Marine Museum. His contribution to human rights can be seen in his service as chairman of the Education Committee and one of its "Lifetime Members" of the Southport-Brunswick County Chapter of the N.A.A.C.P.

Finally, upon leaving the historic and beautiful city of Southport and county of Brunswick to return to his native home and community in rural Halifax County, Francis could not forget the young generation and other wonderful people he was leaving behind. He felt especially attached to the memory of his wonderful and loving wife, a native and fellow-teacher of Southport, who passed away in the Spring of 1990. He was of special concern for a group of handicapped children and adults whom he and his wife had the rare privilege and honor to serve by providing them a home in the time of need.

It was with the above expressed sentiment that Francis established an Endowed Scholarship at the Brunswick Community College in the corpus of \$25,000.00 in honor of his wife and devoted friend for 42 years. The endowment is known as the Annie E. Francis Scholarship Endowment for the physically handicapped. The income from this endowment will be used to pay on the tuition of any qualified physically-handicapped student of the greatest need who may apply in an effort to help themselves in their struggle to meet the awful challenge and demands of a competitive world.

End